

Vertigo

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No 820 August 2018



NEW ZEALAND
ALPINE CLUB

Wellington Section Monthly Bulletin

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TGR SKI MOVIE NIGHT
One night only
Tickets limited
so don't delay
[Click to book now!!!](#)

Abseiling from a high point on the flanks of Mount Brown. More [here](#)

Chair's Report

August 2018

I know I've talked before about the approach the Wellington section takes to delivering its snow and rock courses and how great they are. And there is no point encouraging you to sign up for one because they are invariably sold out well in advance - unless you want to sign up for next year.

The following isn't my opinion I'm sharing with you here, it is the consistent view of the students. Nearly every student reports that the 2:1 student to instructor ratio is fantastic and allows them to get the most out of the course. Sadly this is not consistent with NZAC policy which only requires a 6:1 student to instructor ratio. Thanks to a dedicated group of volunteer instructors we are able to run much safer, higher quality courses at much lower cost. Year on year, these volunteers give up their weekends and part of their day jobs to deliver these courses. Without them we would not be able to run our courses and those of you who want to improve your rock and snow craft skills would have to fork out hundreds and in some cases, thousands of dollars more. Most likely for a higher student instructor ratio as well.

Our courses also provide our primary source of new members, some of who eventually go on to becoming instructors themselves. So the contribution of our volunteers goes way beyond delivering courses. They help to sustain and grow the club as well. I would like to send them all a heartfelt thanks (and I hope you will too) for their invaluable contribution. Next time you are at a section night and happen to be talking to one of our instructors, you might just say, 'great job' or something to that effect or better still offer to buy them a drink or even better than that, volunteer yourself.

"We make a living by what we get, but we make a life by what we give." — Winston Churchill

If you have any comments on what you like or don't like send an email to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz or tweet us [@NZACWellington](https://twitter.com/NZACWellington).

Simon

From the Editor

From my own personal experience I endorse Simon's support of the 2:1 student instructor ratio. This means every student must engage - the very best way to learn.

I've received a fine selection of entries for our Wellington Section Photo Competition. Come along on Wednesday evening to see all the entries, find out who the category winners are and to have your say about who the overall "peoples' choice" winner should be.

Don't miss out on a ticket to our newest event
- TGR Ski Movie Night - more [here](#).

If you have a trip to share just type up a report of between half and three pages as a Word document, email it to occasionalclimber@gmail.com with one to six jpeg images and I'll format it for Vertigo.

Simon Williamson
Chair: NZAC Wellington

Peter

Section News

September Section night

From 6pm Wed 26th September, Penny Webster will take us through her quest to climb all of New Zealand's 3,000m peaks.

All Section night talks are held at The Third Eye, Tuatara Brewery, level 2, 30 Arthur Street, from 6pm. Also a good place to collect or return hired climbing gear.

Section nights beyond September

Wed 31st October, Nigel Roberts will present his journey up the highest peaks in each of USA's 50 states.

Wed 28th November, Nina Sawicki will take us on a journey to Kanchenjunga base camp in Nepal.

No section nights December and January.

Wed 27th February 2019, climbing and pizzas at Hangdogs TBC

Wed 27th March, Paul Maxim will talk about peaks, places and prints - as a climber and writer, how he has been able to very successfully combined these two interests.

Leading the first pitch of Indian summer, an awesome route on the Remarkables East face
Iain Burgon, Rock Climbing Category Winner 2017



Section News

Gear Hire

Don't forget the Section has gear for hire: avalanche transceivers, ice axes, shovels, stakes, hammers, helmets, crampons, probes, PLBs, ice hammers (entry level).

To hire gear please fill in the form [here](#). Why not come to a last Wednesday of the month Section evening to collect or return gear.

Each item costs \$5 per week with the exception of PLBs – PLBs are free but require a deposit of \$50 refundable on return.

A little bit of advance notice would be appreciated as gear often needs to be retrieved from the gear store in Lower Hutt. Gear collections and drop-offs are usually available in the city during the working day or at section night.

Accommodation on Mt Ruapehu

Our snowcraft courses for the past few years have been run out of the Manawatu Tramping and Skiing Club lodge on Whakapapa. We're always made to feel welcome and the lodge is well situated a short walk from the top of the Bruce Road. Membership to the club is extremely reasonable - \$35 per year or \$50 for a family membership. Members stay at the lodge for \$36 a night including food. If you're looking for somewhere to base yourself for your winter pursuits or rock-climbing over the summer months go to www.mtsc.org.nz/joining.php to find out more about joining the club.

Expedition Fund 2018 [Call for Applications and Donations](#)

XII ISMM World Congress On Mountain Medicine

21-24 November 2018, Kathmandu, Nepal, www.ismm2018.org, [email](#)

Nominations open for NZAC Volunteer of the Year 2018

NZAC Volunteer of the Year (VOTY) is awarded at each AGM. Individuals and Sections nominate an NZAC volunteer that they think have done great work over the course of the previous year. Please complete the [online nomination form](#) no later than 1 Oct 18.

UIAA ice climbing season

The calendar for the 2019 UIAA ice climbing season is now in place. Read [more](#).

International Snow Science Workshop preliminary programme [here](#)

Notices

NZAC instruction courses open for registration

Click for more details [Ice Climbing](#) [Ski Touring](#) (and the new guide [here](#)) [High Alpine Skills](#)

One more month before applications for the 2018 FMC Expedition Scholarships close

FMC is proud to offer Youth Scholarships (age under 30) for the eighth year running, and the Simon Bell Memorial Scholarship (no age restrictions) for the third consecutive year. To enquire [email](#) our Executive Officer. Applications close on Friday 14 September 2018.

[Ski-fields](#) offering NZAC members a discount for the 2018 season

NZAC Mountain Medicine Weekend

NZAC Unwin Lodge Aoraki Mt Cook will be hosting its first ever weekend of Mountain Medicine workshops this 13/14 October. The weekend will offer climbers, trampers, mountaineers and skiers the chance to learn about mountain medicine from experts in the field and share knowledge and experience with others interested in Mountain Medicine. [Click](#) to read the full event/workshop info and to register.

NZAC Spring Photography Workshop - Aoraki

21-24 Sept 2018, based out of NZ Alpine Club - Unwin Lodge, Mt Cook

Professional photographer Rob Brown returns to host a Spring Photography Workshop- for members who are beginner/intermediate photographers wanting to improve their outdoor photography skills.

[Click](#) for more details and to register to secure your spot.

2018 UIAA Mountain Protection Award - applications now open

As a member of the UIAA the NZAC is eligible to enter individual or group projects for this award.

Please email the General Manager, [Karen Tait](#), if you have a project for entry. The UIAA Mountain Protection Award (MPA) was created in 2013. During its six years of existence, the annual UIAA Mountain Protection Award (MPA) has made a tangible difference to mountain lives, communities and the environment. It has enabled people to raise finances to build key infrastructures, conduct vital research and fulfil pending goals; it has provided an international showcase and communication platform for projects to raise awareness and exchange ideas and initiatives. Not only has it supported local communities, it has fostered its own global community. The Award celebrates innovation and a desire to make a difference. [Click](#) for more.

Bisotun 4th Festival of Big wall Climbing Iran

Kermanshah 20th to 27th October 2018

More details [here](#).

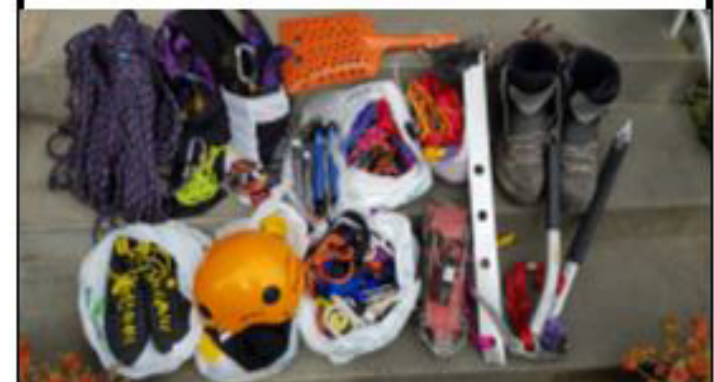
A Walk in the Park?

A deep dive into tramping incidents in New Zealand. Find out [more](#).

Climbing Gear For Sale

Assortment of climbing gear for sale as no longer used. Some equipment in near new condition. Other gear is free as part of bulk sale. Gear is worth well over the asking price.

8.8mm Beal rope; Snowstake; Footfangs; Salewa crampons- no straps; Ice hammer; Curved black diamond ice axe; One planet yellow mountaineering coat; Size 9 Sportiva rock boots (hardly worn) & chalk bag; Size 9.5-10 Scarpa climbing boots -free; 4 x ice screws; Slings & Prussiks; 5 x Quickdraws; Assortment of hexes and wires; 2 x Jumars; 1 x Troll harness; 1 x Rock Empire harness; 2 x Pear shaped karrabinas; 1 x abseiling device; 1x Half dome helmet. Price is \$700:00



Contact Patrick on 0275437082 or email: padraigmacc@xtra.co.nz

Coming Trips, Courses, Events

All our planned South Island trips come with the added bonus that rental vehicle costs for Wellington Section members are covered by the Section.

If you're uncertain about the skill level required with any of the trips, would like to register your interest or to find out more, email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the Committee can help with advertising and logistics.

When	What and where
TBA depending on level of interest	Self rescue course for new comers Titahi Bay, expressions of interest sought wellington@alpineclub.org.nz
26 Aug	National Annual Photo Competition Entries received until this date. More here .
27 Aug to 7 Sep	Have your say about how our Club will be governed Voting will be conducted via an online voting platform called OpaVote. Each member will receive voting instructions and a unique voting link via email. Find out more .
17 September	Teton Gravity Research Ski Movie night From 6.30pm, Victoria University Memorial Theatre. For the first time NZAC Wellington Section is pleased to bring two exciting ski films to stir your imagination and inspire. Two movies - 'High life' and 'Tight Loose' Just \$13 plus online booking fee per member/student See the YouTube trailer <i>Book your tickets here</i>
5 to 7 October	North Island Ski Touring Meet 2018 Based at Tukino Lodge, Mt Ruapehu Info Pack Registration Please contact Mac with any questions A great opportunity to find likeminded people, enjoy some spring ski touring adventures with them and explore Ruapehu's wild side, away from the busy ski fields. Please note this is not a led trip, so when on the meet, groups will need to be able to look after yourselves when away from the lodge.
19 to 22 October (Labour weekend)	Wellington Section Climbing Meet - Paines Ford, Takaka Contact Eric Duggan for more information or to confirm your spot
16 to 19 November	Wellington Section Climbing Meet - Paines Ford, Takaka Contact Eric Duggan for more information or to confirm your spot For members, your transport from the airport to Hangdog Camp ground is subsidised. This is a climbing meet, not an instruction course. You must be able to belay and lead in an outdoor environment and have your own safety and climbing equipment. It is not required to have rope or quickdraws but you need to buddy up with others that have them. Hangdog Camp grounds is the usual accomm situation but you can organise alternative accommodation.
7 to 10 December	Wellington Section Climbing Meet - Castle Hill Contact Stacey Wong for more information or to confirm your spot
13 - 27 April 2019	Wellington Section Trip to Arapiles Please email your expression of interest to Jenny Cossey Fly to Melbourne individually and leave by car in a group from Melbourne on Saturday 13th April. Returning by car to Melbourne on Saturday 27th April. Please note these are the two weeks of the NZ school holidays which includes Good Friday (19th April), Easter Monday (22nd April) and ANZAC Day (25th April). Please book your own air tickets early to suit you. The Wellington section will give a subsidy towards car hire for the trip for a maximum of ten section members who register with the trip organiser Jenny Cossey on a first come first served basis.

This is a one night
only event.
Tickets are limited,
so don't delay.
[Click to book now!!!](#)



Trip Reports

Icy encounters above Bush Stream

Camping up Bush Stream in Aoraki Mount Cook National Park

Words and pictures Peter Laurenson



Camping in the mountains in mid winter is cold. I have a down Macpac bag that's meant to be cosy at minus seven. It wasn't. Mind you, I only had a half length therma rest and the ground cold seeped up through the tent floor and my bag into my lower legs and feet all night, even with two pairs of thick socks on. And in winter the nights are long.

It wasn't all suffering on a recent trip in to the upper reaches of Bush Stream in the Aoraki Mount Cook National Park though. For one, we choppered in to our campsite rather than slog 5kms up the rocky bed of Bush Stream from the road end near Glen Tanner. That meant we had luxuries like precooked dinners and red wine. When shared across our party of five, a trip in and out was only \$220 per head – money well spent I say.

Unlike many these days, my pathway into climbing was hiking rather than rock climbing. I'm still more inclined to tackle a route that includes a summit if the going's good, rather than focus primarily on technical climbing. But on this trip most of my companions owned many more cams, quick draws and ice screws than I. Our focus was the pursuit of vertical ice and I hoped to learn plenty from them.

The weather had been all over the place in the week leading up to our departure. The forecast was sufficiently bad just a day out to postpone. But then Piotr Nowak, our Christchurch based trip leader, called me on Thursday morning after the forecast did a miraculous U turn over night, explaining we were on again. Could I sort a flight?

Our chopper touched down beside Bush Stream at 1,150 metres, about 1pm next day. We immediately set up camp and geared up. Looking north, up the flanks of Mount Brown, we could see some near vertical white lines extending upwards from the steep sloping scree - worth a look.

Paul Knott and James Hobson, Canterbury Section NZAC members and very capable technical climbers made up one rope. Piotr, also a good technical climber, kindly opted to lead the rookies - myself and his partner Kim, who had never been in crampons. After establishing a belay stance at the base of the steep ice we enjoyed climbing a 60 metre pitch. Paul and Piotr led on two ropes and we all abseiled off a V thread anchor, my first time doing that. For Kim the whole thing was new and her ear to ear grin suggested this pitch would be the first of many for her.





Above - The view east, down Bush Stream, from the shelf we used to access the ice. Our campsite is near where the stream leading out of the couloir meets Bush Stream. The couloir we climbed the day before is just visible at top centre, across the valley

Right - James leading a vertical 20 metre pitch - taking it calmly

For more captioned images and a route map www.occasionalclimber.co.nz



By then it was nearly dusk, so we retreated to our campsite. It had been a great way to get started and, while up higher at about 1,500 metres, we'd spotted several other potential ice routes to the south, across the valley.

Next morning, after the sun had risen, we crawled out of our bags, stretched chilled bones and got ready to head up the south side of the valley. As we climbed, a couloir revealed itself from behind a rock buttress. It offered very enjoyable cramponing up through a system of exposed shelves. Paul and James had their sights set on a frozen waterfall, with further possibilities looming up above that too.

This time, given the extra exposure and fully vertical nature of the frozen waterfall, Kim and Piotr retreated while I tagged along with Paul and James. With youthful vigour James led up the hard, vertical ice. His experience told him not to rush it, otherwise his upper body would get over pumped and lactic acid laden muscles would translate in to fear. With frequent pauses to let the blood flow back into one arm then the next, he patiently made his way up the pitch, placing ice screw protection as he went.



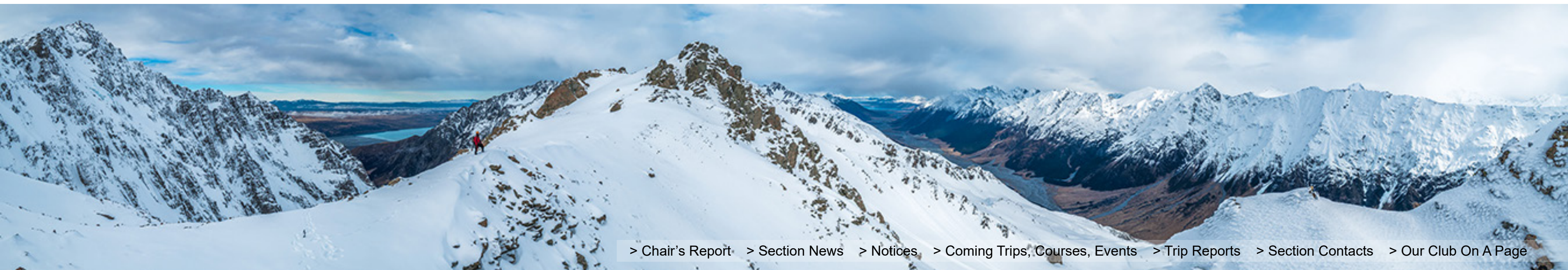
Then it was my turn. Even with the total safety of a top rope I still wasn't sure if I'd be able to follow James. It was hard. My gear wasn't as specialised for ice and nor was my technique – or lack of. By the time I'd smashed and grunted my way up 20 metres of vertical ice to the lip, where the gradient relented, my hands were numb and my muscles pumped to the extent that landing accurate axe placements had become a bit of a lottery. It was a relief to peer over the lip and see the rope leading up to a snow shelf not much further above, where James had set up a belay.

Up beside James, while the blood painfully gushed back into my numbed hands, Paul also followed up. I felt a little better about my own performance when I heard Paul grunting in pain after also clearing the lip. Because I wasn't able to clean the route of the ice screws on my way up he had had to, therefore spending longer on the face than me. His hands were also numbed and now giving him grief as the blood returned.

Although a short pitch, James and Paul judged it to be grade 4 ice terrain due to the verticality and hardness of the ice – a superb learning experience for me and enough to tell me that I won't be leading any grade 4 ice pitches anytime soon. There was more climbing to be had directly above us, but both Paul and I were satisfied to back off. I got a fine lesson in V thread placement, then we rapped back down our pitch.

As we descended the shelves back into the couloir we caught up with Piotr and Kim, who were practicing snowcraft skills where it counted. It was excellent terrain to apply a range of climbing techniques. We all trudged into camp late afternoon at wine o'clock.

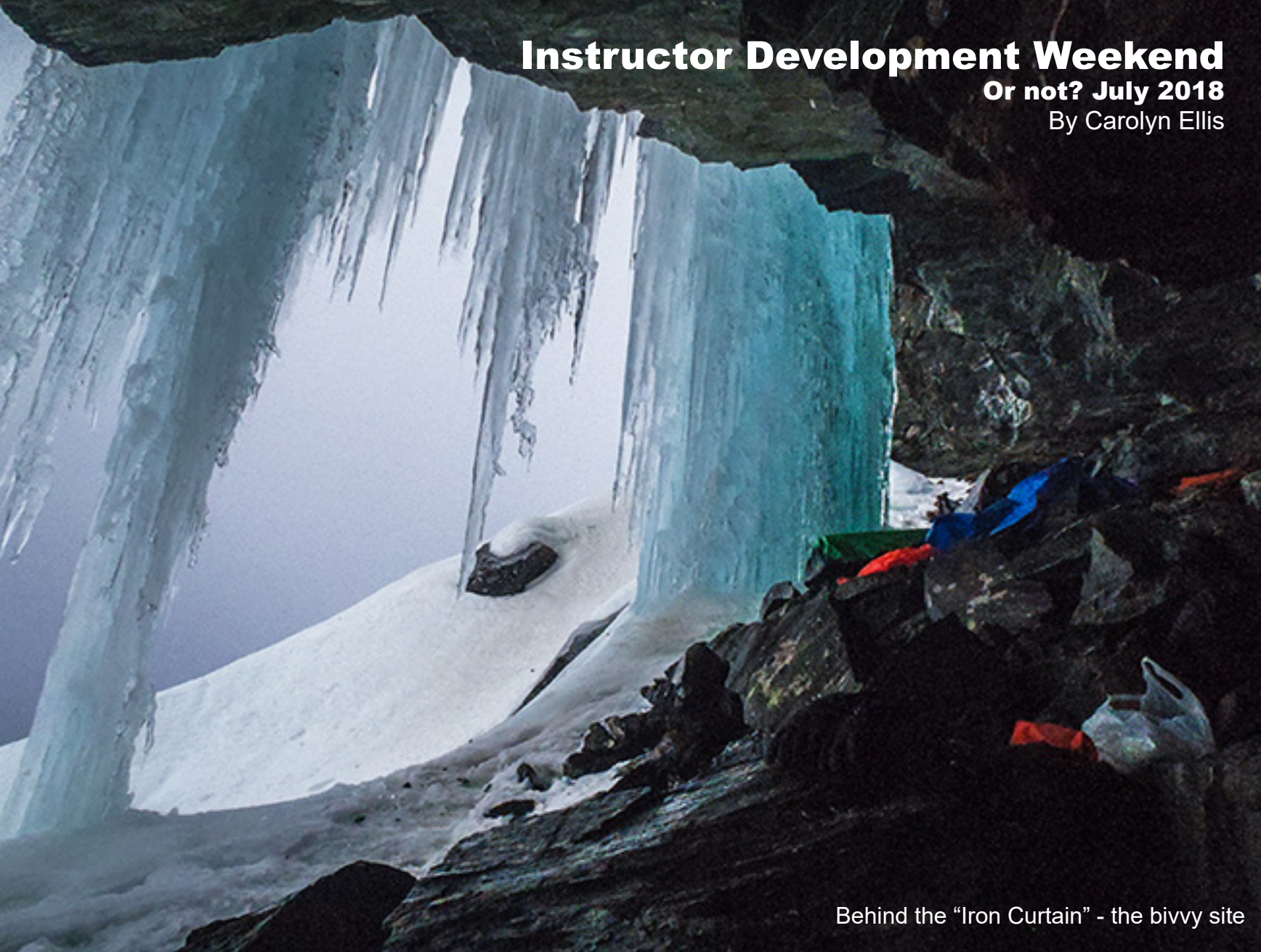
On Sunday, our last day, Paul and James went north again in pursuit of more vertical ice while Piotr, Kim and I headed up valley into the Cirque at its head. The terrain was friendly, but the dry, unconsolidated powder snow didn't make for easy going. As we ascended towards a saddle at 2,150m we saw various other ice climbing options on both sides of the valley. A family of four Chamois grazed on lean pickings ahead but, when they saw us, trotted off up into the bluffs on the southern side. On the saddle we enjoyed an expansive panorama, taking in Mt Brown to our left, the cirque wall leading south to Mauka Atua, Dobson River valley, to our right and the Naumann Range, far right. A brief lunch stop was all we had time for – our chopper was due back at 4pm – nice.



Instructor Development Weekend

Or not? July 2018

By Carolyn Ellis



Behind the “Iron Curtain” - the bivy site

With winter well and truly here, it was time to get stuck into some instructor development, before our Snowcraft courses commenced for the season. Unlike previous years, there was no national Instructor Development Course planned, so the Section Committee looked into how we might fill that gap. With a few ideas on the table, the first one to trial was to head to the South Island, hire a guide and get some quality time in the hills honing our skills. We booked our flights to Queenstown with the plan for the four of us to spend a long weekend in the Remarkables with a guide. We’d agreed that we’d fly in to Wye Creek to maximise our time in the snow and then walk out down Wye Creek to the road. Unfortunately I was at the tail end of a cold that had left me with a nasty hacking cough – sounded dreadful, but I was feeling markedly better than I had been earlier in the week. I was certainly not a delight to be around!

The forecast for the weekend wasn’t brilliant and the avalanche forecast wasn’t great either, but the decision was made to head in and make the most of it – all on the proviso that the focus was on skill development. The flight was great fun and, within a few minutes, we were touching down near to the Adventure Consultants camp next to Wye Creek. Like kids in a candy shop we scanned the area and were excited to see plenty of ice. We dumped our sleeping gear, then headed up the hill to the ice for some tuition on ice screw placement and ice climbing techniques. Not quite what we had planned as ice climbing isn’t in the syllabus for any of our courses. After each of us had a couple of climbs, it was time to collect our sleeping gear and head into our bivy spot for the night.

Some hot dinner and drinks were consumed and then it was into cosy sleeping bags and bivy bags for the night. The weather the next day wasn’t too bad but it was a slow start to the day. Only after a late breakfast, we packed up our gear with the plan to spend time on our skill development, before walking down the valley to a cave for the second night’s bivy.

We regrouped at our dropoff spot from the previous day to find that the guide had decided to chopper out. The reason for the decision was not discussed or well communicated, but seemed to be based on me being sick. No-one was happy, least of all me. Four very disappointed instructors.

On our return to Queenstown Airport the four of us sorted out a cabin for the night and then headed out for dinner and a discussion on what to do the following day. The weather forecast was still pretty awful, but we decided the best use of our time was to head up to a ski field and spend the day instructing each other, providing feedback and discussing different teaching techniques. We took advantage of Coronet Peak’s transceiver patch to carry out some transceiver searching, before running through lessons at both Introductory and Intermediate level. We all agreed it was valuable to spend the time coaching and critiquing each other although, of course, we didn’t need to be in Queenstown to do that.

The next day it was time to head for home – one to Auckland on the early flight and the rest of us to Wellington around midday. Or not. The Auckland flight got away ok, but the Wellington flight was delayed, then delayed again, then delayed again and then cancelled. Luckily we were shifted onto a later Wellington flight but it was pretty dull hanging out in the airport for so long.

A few things we learned from our weekend:

- One way to remove the smell of white spirits from a fuel bottle is to pee in it.
- Always get firm quotes for expensive items like helicopter flights – estimates may not be accurate.
- Ensure that you get agreement up front that the group will discuss and agree to any changes to the plan.



Heading up to the ice, Wye Creek

Section Contacts

Powered by volunteers

We're always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. A lot goes on to keep our club going, virtually all powered by volunteers. On the back page is our "Club on a page" summary. It gives an at a glance description of all the things we do, how and why. Feel free to print a copy and pass it on to anyone who might be interested in becoming a member or volunteer. And if you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Role	Name	Contact
Chair person	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Secretary, gear custodian	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Treasurer	Vacant	
Trip co-ordinator	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Section nights, Vertigo, Photocomp	Peter Laurenson	021 446 725
Social media	Marie Kelly	
Club liaison	Keith Munro	
Library, Projects	Alex Waterworth	
General Committee	Matt Pemberton	
General Committee	Guy Dubuis	
General Committee	Joshua Mouat	
Patron	John Nankervis	
Rock drill overseer	Jeremy Tries	027 555 5893



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Alpine Club members can climb any time for \$12
Monday nights show your Alpine Club card and climb for \$10



New routes every week*

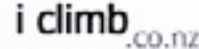
\$1000 worth of new holds in Jan/Feb 2012
New pad in "Da Cave" allowing safe aggressive bouldering

Creating happiness through better climbing

* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



HangDog Rock Climbing Adventures
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Lower Hutt
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info@hangdog.co.nz
www.hangdog.co.nz



Simond alpine equipment direct from the importer



all crampons include anti-balling plates and crampon bag

Ocelot
\$115

MXC 820
\$230

Makalu
\$255

Caiman
\$230



i climb .co.nz

For quick access to our Section's page on the NZAC website, click or scan this QR code



WHAT WE DO

FOR MEMBERS

Facilities

- * Huts
- * Gear
- * Library
- * Discounts

Training

- * Level 1- 3 winter skills
- * Summer rock
- * Instructors

Climbing trips

- * Section
- * National
- * International

FOR MEMBERS AND WIDER PUBLIC

Publications

- * Website
- * Social media
- * Vertigo
- * Guide books

Events

- * Banff mountain film festival
- * Reel Rock
- * Photo comp

Networking

- * Section nights
- * Conferences and meetings
- * Lobbying

HOW WE DO IT

Organise, encourage, support, enable

Inform, entertain, promote

OUR RESOURCES

Volunteer time and capabilities, income from events and gear hire, national office support, sponsorship

WHY WE DO IT

Connecting & developing more climbing & mountaineering people, knowledge, skills & experience, thereby ...

... building lifelong friendships

... protecting and improving access to alpine places

... sustaining and growing climbing and mountaineering achievement

... enhancing alpine safety

... building appreciation, enjoyment and protection of alpine places